Svapramanatva and Svaprakaṣatva: An Inconsistency in Kumārila's Philosophy

The Mīmāṅsā is noted for its unusual view of the authoritativeness and the validity of all cognitions as such. The view is taken from the Jaimini Sūtra 1, 2, and 5, and is developed by both Kumārila and Prabhākara in their respective works of Ślokavārtika and Bṛhati. Kumārila expounds the view in Ślokavārtikā Sūtra 2, in which it is maintained that all cognitions as soon as, and when, they arise are inherently endowed with validity. Thus, starting from the supposition of an inherent quality of truth of the cognitions, what is to be established by subsequent investigation is not their truth but their falsity. The question is asked, wherein can the truth of a cognition lie? It can lie either in its own self or outside itself, i.e., in the excellence of the sense organs, etc. But if the truth of a cognition did not belong to the cognitions and depended upon external conditions, one would have to wait for the actual experiences of life till the ascertainment of their truth by an examination of the external causes of the alleged discrepancy has been established.

Let us take an example. If a man with the intention to write perceives a pen and picks it up, he does so under the assumption of a belief in the validity of his perception. In other words, his cognition is its own 'Pramāṇa'. The 'Pramāṇatva' of the cognition comes from within itself, 'Svatāḥ'. No one after seeing a pen ordinarily broods: "Let me think if this perception of mine is valid, for it may be invalid. Are my senses in perfectly excellent condition and are other circumstances of cognition favorable to a valid perception? Am I sure that it is only a pen I have just seen and no other object, etc.?" If such was the normal procedure of thought after perception, all practical activity of life would become paralyzed. But such, however, is not the case, and this establishes the Self-validity of our cognitions. And therefore only those cogni-

A paper read at the Philosophical Congress held at Hyderabad in December 1939.